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Life-crisis rituals among the Kenuz

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Section Title(S)

LEylet-il-henna: the bride's celebration • LEylet-il-henna: the bride's house

The evening celebration was primarily a festivity, combining singing, feasting, and teasing of the groom. Sometimes it included a *hadra* of the Mirghaneyya order, during which the men chanted mulid and danced zikr. It could become quite elaborate if the couple belonged to different tribes and came from different villages, or if the groom's previous marriage or any other factor, such as a recent death, inhibited his part of the celebration. In the spring of 1963, a young Ababda from Koliseg married the daughter of the head of the Jerbab tribe, in el Khor. His maternal uncle came from Ambarkab to take charge of the celebration, but behaved like a lineage-head rather than an indulgent mother's brother. Since the groom's matrilineal parallel cousin had died in Aswan three months earlier, his uncle objected to most of the features that could be interpreted as celebration, including kaff-dancing. After the procession took the groom to the bride's house in el Khor, however, he could not enforce his proscriptions. This section of the celebration was unusually lively. Long after the event would normally have ended, the guests began dancing in the courtyard, using a rare variety of kaff called *Bisharin*, in which several small groups, each consisting of a woman and three men, danced very vigorously.

533
Music

535
Dance

574
Visiting And
Hospitality

585
Nuptials

765
Mourning

782
Prayers And Sacrifices

788
Ritual

After the guests attending an ordinary wedding had been seated, they were served rose sharbat or sweetened water, followed by plates of dates and peanuts, and later the feast itself, consisting of fatta. The groom received a special dish, filled with meat which he passed around as baraka. This dish might also contain a round loaf of very hard bread, which he was required to

522
Humor533
Music

574
Visiting And
Hospitality

585
Nuptials

788
Ritual

522
Humor

576
Etiquette

585
Nuptials

883
Adolescent Activities

522
Humor

585
Nuptials

689
Social Offenses

883
Adolescent Activities

264 Eating

585 Nuptials

883 Adolescent Activities

LEYLET-IL-HENNA: THE BRIDE'S CELEBRATION

585
Nuptials

593
Family Relationships

She was given a small 62 celebration, much quieter than the public events, and usually confined to her close relatives and a few friends. This was basically a family affair that did not involve the community or her tribe.

784

Avoidance And Taboo

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